

Al Mallette

Sunday Shots



The Twin Tiers' professional baseball fans had best come out of hiding this summer and attend Pioneer games—or they might not have them for years to come.

The 1968 season could be the "severe test" year for Class AA Eastern League baseball in Elmira.

Leon Markson started the ball rolling Thursday night when he protested the city tax expenditure to maintain Dunn Field. Mayor Edward T. Lagonegro kept it going with the statement that soon City Council may be required to decide whether baseball has outlived itself in Elmira.

Lagonegro's choicest statement was, "We're not obliged to continue (professional) baseball for a few hundred people."

This comment, coming from Lagonegro, admittedly is a surprise. He's always been on baseball's bandwagon.

Maybe now, though, with the big tax bite Elmiraans are getting, plus a review of Dunn Field attendance the past few years with championship clubs, the mayor figures the game may be ending.

Believe me, he's not alone in his feeling, either. He'll find a boodle of taxpayers looking for relief, on his side.

THE BASEBALL people, of course, have their point, too. Professional baseball is good for a community. It offers a form of relaxation and recreation. And there is some community publicity value (no one ever has determined how much) in housing a professional team.

The problem for the diehard baseball people is that they are a diminishing group. If they want to keep baseball, they're going to have to go out and battle. In other words they have to get more people into the ball park to prove that the game in Elmira is worth saving.

I, for one, think it is worth saving. Sure, maybe my reasons are prejudiced. Any sportswriters' would be. I just hope Elmira and Twin Tiers fans feel the same way.

MARKSON WAS ASKED if he'd had any reaction since his protest against the high budget figure for the maintenance of Dunn Field.

"Indeed," answered Markson. "And I might add the reaction has really been sensible. I'd say about 7-out-of-8 back me."

"One baseball man, who was, well, sort of wishy-washy in backing me said, 'If your blast helps put 100,000 into Dunn Field this summer, it will have been well worth it.'"

"You see," continued Markson, "the one thing that I don't believe people fully realize is that professional sports today are games of the multi-millionaire sportsman. It's more or less a plaything for them. I don't believe taxpayers in the Elmira area should have to be burdened to support this 'plaything.'"

"Why doesn't someone connected with local baseball get hard in demands with Baltimore and make them pay the freight—or at least some of it? Boy, I remember when gentlemen like Levi Ginsberg and Bill Lande used to do it. Don't we have any Ginsbergs or Landes today?"

Markson also commented that maybe the City Council should look into the idea of making Dunn Field a recreation complex—ball park, basketball courts, skating rink, etc., opening it up to all kinds of recreational programs—as long as the maintenance is being provided by the city.

ANDY COHEN, THE old duck-caller of the New York Giants and Elmira Pioneer infielders, was a recent Elmira visitor and lauded the Jan. 29 All Sports Banquet as a "Super Show" the likes of which he never before has heard of for anything but a big city. "With Lindsey Nelson, Duffy Daugherty, Jersey Joe Walcott and Tommy Richardson, you folks have four of the biggest names on the banquet circuit on one show. Add Earl Wilson and those others and, believe me, it's a Super Show." . . . Cohen headed back to El Paso, where he's coach of the University of Texas at El Paso baseball team. "Baseball is new at the school," said Andy. "We're trying to build it up. And we're having good success."

HARRY (RED) O'NEILL and Jack Radzavicz are two local ex-football greats who stamped themselves among the coaching fraternity elite. Both enjoyed, and were honored for, unbeaten seasons.

O'Neill, the great running back of Art Hirst's Elmira High elevens of 1934-35-36-37, coached the Sleepy Hollow Horsemen to a second straight undefeated season. He carries a 16-game win streak into the 1968 season, the same length as the one he helped Elmira achieve in 1935-36-37.

Radzavicz, Horseheads star of the early Fifties, made his debut as Cortland High varsity coach and followed in the footsteps of predecessor John Moiseichik with an unbeaten season—plus the most potent offense in the history of Cortland football.

Radzavicz' Tigers totaled 293 points for eight games—an amazing average of 37 per game.

Radzavicz followed the pattern of successful Cortland grid coaches. Glen Brown and Moiseichik both started their lengthy careers with unbeaten seasons.

A tip of our hat to both O'Neill and Radzavicz.